more porous," she says.

For over 15 years, Kakar-Saxena nurtured her gallery in the quaint southern neighbourhood of Lado Sarai, where a young, more eclectic cohort was drawn to the space's improvisational nature. However, over time, especially after COVID, its limitations became apparent, particularly in terms of accessibility and scale. "What was once considered central, like Lado Sarai and even Saket, began to feel increasingly peripheral. The infrastructure had a role to play too—the 'urban village' no longer felt as charming during the monsoon," the gallerist says. In comparison, the Art Deco-inspired building in Defence Colony allowed her to rethink how art is presented, appealing more to veterans and even international travellers staying in nearby luxury hotels.

The reasons were the same even a decade ago for Anahita Taneja, co-founder and director, Shrine Empire, who saw potential in Defence Colony as early as 2017, when she had only two other galleries for company. For a space showcasing art, it's rather unique to be set in a basement, which doesn't offer the height a white cube requires. With Shrine Empire, Taneja broke the white cube mould and tinkered with depth, materiality and intimacy.

In hindsight, moving to Defence Colony proved to be a rather lucrative and timely decision for Shrine Empire. And as of April 2026, the gallery is reopening in a different spot within the same neighbourhood to expand the purview of its offerings, which now include a "reading salon" and a collaboration with a coffee brand.

Defence Colony might just be the gift that keeps giving—and some gallerists' best-kept secret that the larger community is only just waking up to. ■

—Arshia

EXHIBITION ▼

BACK TO THE FUTURE

A SPECULATIVE NARRATIVE TIES TOGETHER RONNY SEN'S PHOTOGRAPHS ON VIEW AT TARQ, MUMBAI

The Sun Rises in the East, a solo exhibition by Ronny Sen at TARQ, presents 10 works that blur fiction, research and photographic practice. On view until April 18, the exhibition is set in a speculative Bengal of 2045 shaped by climate collapse and rogue artificial intelligence, unfolding as both narrative and visual inquiry.

For Sen, this convergence is not imagined but already present. "I arrived at this intersection by treating climate collapse and AI as conditions that already coexist," he says. Situating the work in eastern India allows him to foreground layered histories of technological ambition and human crisis.

At the centre of the exhibition is a "wooden dog", an early analogue learning machine conceived in the 1940s. At once archival and fictional, the object resists fixed meaning. "The dog allows the machine to sit between categories: animal, tool, relic, companion," Sen explains. Encountered in the ruins of former military airfields, the machine now exists alongside a teenage boy, forming a relationship defined by ambiguity.

Working through constructed images and speculative text, Sen positions photography as both evidence and proposition. "The work uses fiction as a way of working through reality," he says.

The exhibition reflects on the afterlives of technology and the limits of machine intelligence. "Storage is not the same as memory," Sen observes. What emerges is a speculative archive, one that reassembles fragmentary histories across time while leaving their meanings unresolved. ■

—Nikhil Sardana

The exhibition is on till Apr. 18



BETWEEN WORLDS A still depicting a teenage boy's relationship with a 'wooden' dog



"I ARRIVED AT THE INTERSECTION OF CLIMATE COLLAPSE AND AI AS CONDITIONS THAT ALREADY COEXIST. FICTION BECOMES A WAY TO WORK THROUGH THAT REALITY"